

# Soul, Immortality and Rebirth — Solved Answer-Writing Toolkit

**17 verified PYQs and six timed original models**

Model answers are independent learner practice, not official UPSC answer keys.  
Exact verified wording and ownership come only from the repository PYQ ledgers.  
Locked timed bands: 10 marks = 150-200 words; 15 marks = 250-300 words;  
20 marks = 340-400 words. Each declaration below is computed from the answer text.

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## Verified PYQs through 2026

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The owner has 17 verified parts in 2018-2025 and no primary-owned part in 2026.

### Verified PYQ 1 — 2018 Q5(b) · 10 marks

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**Exact verified question:** How far is it plausible to argue that the anti-theistic religions' stand on the concept of rebirth is philosophically significant?

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

#### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** The anti-theistic religions (Buddhism, and in its own way Jainism) are philosophically significant precisely because they show that rebirth is detachable both from a creator-God and from an immortal soul-substance.

- **Doctrine.** Buddhism affirms re-becoming (*punarbhava*) while denying a permanent self (*anatman*): what continues is a dependently arisen causal stream, not a transmigrating substance. Jainism has an eternal *jiva* but no God who administers karma; the moral law is self-regulating.
- **Significance (three claims).** (1) Karma needs no divine judge -- desert is discharged by an impersonal law, answering the problem of evil differently from theism. (2) Rebirth needs no immortal soul -- continuity, not substance, suffices (the flame-to-flame model). (3) Liberation (*nirvana*, *kevala*) requires neither grace nor union with God.
- **Objection -> reply.** If nothing permanent persists, who is reborn and who is liberated? Reply: the later stream is "neither the same nor wholly other"; moral responsibility rests on causal connectedness, not identity of substance.

**Verdict.** The stand is significant because it separates the *machinery* of karma-rebirth-liberation from theism and from soul-substance, proving that the Indian moral cosmos is not logically wedded to either.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ Rebirth is causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates, not transmigration of a numerically identical substance.

**Measured model-answer words:** 200

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it reads "significant" as a modal/structural > claim (what rebirth does NOT require) rather than as praise, and names the > exact anti-substantialist and anti-theistic points.

### Verified PYQ 2 — 2018 Q7(c) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Evaluate the concept of Bhakti (Devotion) as a pathway to attain liberation.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

## Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Bhakti is a complete path to liberation in the theistic Vedāntas and a preparatory discipline in Advaita; its philosophical contribution is structural -- it relocates liberation from achievement to reception.

- **Define the criterion.** A "pathway" must be assessed for accessibility, sufficiency and terminus -- not merely described.
- **Textual base.** *Gīta* 18.66 (*carama-sloka*: abandon all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone), 9.22 and 9.32 on accessibility; *Bhagavata* 7.5.23 lists the nine limbs (*navadha bhakti*): *śravaṇa*, *kīrtana*, *smaraṇa*, *pada-sevāna*, *arcana*, *vandana*, *dāśya*, *sakhya*, *ātma-nivedana*.
- **Typology (marks lie here).** *para* vs *apara*; *vaidhī* vs *raganuga*; *saguna* (Tulsidas, Mira) vs *nirguna* (Kabir, Nanak) -- the latter showing bhakti needs a personal focus, not an iconic form.
- **Systematic positions.** Ramanuja: bhakti as *dhruvanusmṛti*, with *prapatti* as the accessible alternative; grace decisive; *marjara* vs *markata* dispute on grace/effort. Madhva: *jñāna-purvaka-sneha*. Caitanya: *prema* as a fifth *purusārtha*. Advaita: bhakti is *citta-suddhi*, preparatory not liberating.
- **Objection -> reply.** Love presupposes duality, so bhakti cannot deliver Advaitic identity -> Advaita agrees and so classes it as means, not end; the theistic schools deny identity is the goal at all.

**Verdict.** Bhakti's significance is not emotional but structural: it makes mokṣa a matter of grace (reception) rather than qualification (achievement).

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ *Bhakti* is loving devotion to a personal God held, in the theistic Vedāntas and the Bhakti traditions, to be a **direct means (*sādhana*) of liberation** — and, crucially, one available irrespective of caste, gender, language or scholastic training. **Textual base (cite precisely).**

✓ *Bhagavad Gītā* chs. 7–12 and the concluding *carama-śloka* **18.66** (*sarva-dharmān parityajya mām ekaṃ śaraṇaṃ vraja* — abandon all dharmas, take refuge in Me alone); **9.22** on the Lord securing what the exclusively devoted lack; **9.32** on the accessibility of the path.

**Measured model-answer words:** 291

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- criterion-first evaluation, precise verse > citation in order, the grace/effort dispute named, and the achievement-> > reception thesis stated explicitly.

## Verified PYQ 3 — 2019 Q8(a) · 20 marks

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**Exact verified question:** State and explain the doctrines of Karma, Rebirth and Reincarnation in Hinduism.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

## Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Karma, rebirth and reincarnation are linked but non-identical: karma is the mechanism, rebirth the field, and "reincarnation" a school-specific substantialist reading that Buddhism refuses. Define each before expounding.

- **Karma.** Act together with its unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*); classified as *sancita* (stored), *prarabdha* (ripening now) and *agami* (future). It is moral causation, not fatalism -- *purusakara* (effort) operates within *daiva*.
- **Rebirth.** *Punarjanma* within beginningless *samsara*; the subtle body (*suksma-sarira*) carries *samskaras* across lives. *Gita* 2.22 (worn-out garments) and 9.21 (return from heaven when merit is exhausted) show even heaven is a within-*samsara* stage.
- **Reincarnation vs rebirth.** Reincarnation (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes a SUBSTANTIAL soul re-entering a body (Vedanta, Nyaya, Jainism). Rebirth is the wider, neutral term and the ONLY correct one for Buddhism's *punarbhava* without a transmigrating self.
- **Contrast.** Resurrection -- one life, divine re-constitution, final judgement (Cullmann's opposition of Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection).
- **Criticism -> reply.** Memory objection and victim-blaming risk; reply -- memory is not continuity, and karma explains without licensing social blame.

**Verdict.** Karma supplies the mechanism, rebirth the field, and reincarnation a substantialist reading of that field which Buddhism rejects.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series. They are not variants of one idea: they differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos and identity-bearer. **Two Western strands that are often wrongly merged.** ✓ **Immortality of the soul** is Greek/Platonic: the soul is naturally deathless and death releases it from the body. **Resurrection of the dead** is Hebrew-Christian-Islamic: the person is a **psychosomatic unity**, so survival requires God to restore the whole person; death is real and defeat is reversed only by divine act. **Oscar Cullmann** (*Immortality of the Soul or Resurrection of the Dead?*, 1955) argues the two are theologically **opposed**, not complementary — a high-value citation. **The identity problem, both ways.** ⚠ *For resurrection:* the **gap problem** (what exists between death and resurrection?) and the **re-assembly problem** (the classical "cannibal" objection — if matter is shared between bodies, whose atoms are raised?).

**Measured model-answer words:** 349

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it obeys "state AND explain" by defining all > three separately, then interlocking them, and it nails the reincarnation/rebirth > distinction the question is built to test.

## Verified PYQ 4 — 2020 Q5(b) · 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** The concept of 'Immortality' is a basic presupposition of religion. Elaborate your answer.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Immortality functions as a basic presupposition of religion because most traditions require some post-mortem continuant to bear desert, judgement or liberation -- but the presupposition takes at least three different forms, and Buddhism shows it is not strictly necessary.

- **Why presupposed.** Moral seriousness (desert beyond this life), the hope of liberation/salvation, and the meaningfulness of ritual for the dead all seem to need something that survives death.
- **Three forms.** (1) Greek/Platonic natural immortality of a simple soul; (2) Semitic resurrection, where the psychosomatic person is re-constituted by God (not a natural property but a divine act -- Cullmann, 1955); (3) Indian eternal *atman/jiva* transmigrating until liberation.
- **The counter-example.** Buddhism grounds desert and liberation on a causal stream (*anatman*), so immortality is a common but not indispensable presupposition -- continuity is what is really required.

**Verdict.** "Immortality" is a widespread and structurally important presupposition of religion, but the deeper presupposition is CONTINUITY of a morally accountable subject, which Buddhism secures without an immortal soul.

**Analytical expansion. Body/brain objection:** systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions pressures separable-soul theories.

**Measured model-answer words:** 182

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it elaborates the claim (as asked) but refuses to > overclaim, distinguishing the forms of the presupposition and citing the > Buddhist limiting case.

## Verified PYQ 5 — 2020 Q8(c) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Do you accept that Knowledge, Action and Devotion are the means to attain liberation in Indian tradition? Discuss.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Knowledge, action and devotion are all means to liberation, but means of DIFFERENT kinds; whether they are alternative, sequential or combined is settled by a prior question -- is liberation produced or uncovered?

- **Apparatus (deploy early).** Direct means (*saksat-sadhana*) vs remote aid (*arad-upakaraka*); means vs qualification (*adhikara*); production model vs removal model of moksa.
- **Positions.** *Purva-Mimamsa*: karma alone (the *purvapaksa*). *Sankara*: jnana alone removes *avidya*; he rejects *jnana-karma-samuccaya*; karma and *upasana* only purify (*sadhana-catustaya*; *sravana-manana-nididhyasana*). *Ramanuja*: karma -> jnana -> bhakti, with *prapatti* as the accessible alternative -- a graded *samuccaya*. *Madhva*: knowledge-grounded bhakti, *prasada* decisive.
- **The Gita's signal.** 5.4-5: only the immature call Samkhya (knowledge) and Yoga (action) different -- which is why Sankara, Ramanuja and Tilak could each claim the text. Vivekananda's four yogas match temperament (psychological, not metaphysical, pluralism).
- **Objection -> reply.** "Convergence" is diplomatic mush -> reply: they converge in FUNCTION (removing egoic self-appropriation) but diverge in TERMINUS (identity vs communion); say this rather than harmonising.

**Verdict.** Karma qualifies, bhakti receives, jnana removes; their relation follows from each school's answer to whether liberation is produced or uncovered.

**Analytical expansion. The exact question.** ⚠️ Are knowledge, action and devotion **alternative** routes (choose one), **sequential** stages (one leads to the next), or **combined** (all three jointly)? Every Vedāntic school answers differently, and naming the disagreement *is* the answer. **The analytic apparatus (deploy this early; it is what separates a 7 from a 12).** ⚠️ **Direct means (*sākṣāt-sādhana*) vs auxiliary/remote aid (*ārād-upakāraka*).** **Means vs qualification (*adhikāra*):** karma may qualify one for knowledge without being a means to liberation. **Production model vs removal model** of liberation: if mokṣa is a *result to be produced*, action can produce it; if it is the *removal of an error*, only knowledge can remove it. Śaṅkara's entire case rests on the second.

**Measured model-answer words:** 292

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it names the disagreement instead of harmonising, > and uses the production/removal cut to explain WHY schools differ.

## Verified PYQ 6 — 2021 Q6(a) · 20 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Discuss the concept of immortality of soul with special reference to Hindu tradition.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** In the Hindu tradition the immortality of the soul is affirmed across schools, but on different grounds and with different consequences for liberation; it is best read as the eternity of a continuity-bearer rather than one uniform doctrine.

- **Vedanta.** The *atman* is eternal and self-luminous; *Gita* 2.23 gives the canonical image that weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the embodied self. Advaita: *atman* = Brahman; Viśiṣṭadvaita: the *jīva* is an eternal mode of God.
- **Nyaya-Vaiśeṣika.** The self is an eternal substance, but consciousness is adventitious to it -- hence *apavarga* is cessation of pain and of consciousness.
- **Samkhya-Yoga.** *Puruṣa* is eternal, plural, contentless witness, isolated by nature (*kevala*).
- **Comparison with the West.** Plato argues immortality a priori (Phaedo); the Hindu case rests on scriptural testimony and substance-metaphysics, not on the Forms.
- **Critique -> reply.** The soul's simplicity does not entail indestructibility (Kant's paralogism), and there is no memory of past lives -> reply: continuity is carried by *samskaras* in the subtle body, distinct from psychological memory.

**Verdict.** Hindu "immortality of the soul" is the eternity of a continuity- bearer (*atman/jīva/puruṣa*), variously conceived, and it grounds -- but does not by itself deliver -- liberation.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✅ The enduring self bears karmic continuity through embodiments until liberating knowledge or God-centred realisation ends bondage. **Argument.** ✅ Ordinary identity across changing states points to a witness; karmic responsibility requires continuity; *śruti*

discloses the self's deeper nature. Advaita locates bondage in ignorance; Viśiṣṭādvaita in dependence and karma overcome through knowledge, devotion and grace. **Presupposition.** ⚠️ Personal continuity requires more than causal succession, and scriptural testimony is valid in supersensible matters.

**Distinction.** ✅ Advaita mokṣa is not the annihilation of an individual entity but sublation of mistaken individuality; Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves the jīva eternally. **Canonical example.** ✅ The *Gītā* compares embodiment to changing garments; use as canonical illustration, not independent demonstration.

**Objection → reply.** ⚠️ No memory of prior lives weakens identity. Replies distinguish memory from continuity and invoke latent dispositions, though empirical warrant remains contested. **Body/brain objection:** systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions pressures separable-soul theories. It does not by itself deductively prove that no subject can survive, but it shifts the burden to an account of interaction, identity and evidence.

**Measured model-answer words:** 366

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it keeps "Hindu tradition" plural (Vedānta, > Nyāya, Sāṃkhya) instead of collapsing it, and cites the verified Gita 2.23 image.

## Verified PYQ 7 — 2021 Q6(b) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Elucidate the concept of liberation according to Advaita Vedānta. Explain the role of knowledge in the attainment of liberation.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** For Advaita, liberation (*mokṣa*) is the realisation of the *ātman*'s identity with Brahman through the removal of ignorance (*avidyā*); knowledge (*jñāna*) is therefore the sole direct means.

- **Nature of liberation.** *Mokṣa* is not a producible effect but the eternally accomplished nature of the self, obscured by *avidyā*. It comes as *jīvanmukti* (freedom while living, the body coasting on *prarabdha* like a spun wheel) and *videhamukti* (at the body's fall).
- **Role of knowledge.** Since bondage is ignorance, only knowledge can remove it, as light removes darkness. Sāṅkara rejects *jñāna-karma-samuccaya*; action and *upāsana* generate *citta-suddhi* and the *sādhana-catustaya*, and knowledge matures through *śravaṇa-manana-nididhyāsana*.
- **Provenance (Griffiths).** Bondage is a beginningless superimposition (*adhyāsa*) -- the rope taken for a snake -- so *mokṣa* is "not acquired but acknowledged"; knowledge only removes the error.
- **Objection → reply.** If knowledge destroys karma, why does the body remain? → already-fructifying *prarabdha* is distinguished from accumulated and future karma.

**Verdict.** Advaitic liberation is a cognitive-existential awakening, and knowledge is the direct means because liberation is uncovered, not produced.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✅ The enduring self bears karmic continuity through embodiments until liberating knowledge or God-centred realisation ends bondage. **Argument.** ✅ Ordinary identity across changing states points to a witness; karmic responsibility requires continuity; *śruti* discloses the self's deeper nature. Advaita locates bondage in ignorance; Viśiṣṭādvaita in dependence and karma overcome through knowledge, devotion and grace. **Presupposition.** ⚠️ Personal continuity

requires more than causal succession, and scriptural testimony is valid in supersensible matters.

**Distinction.** ✓ Advaita mokṣa is not the annihilation of an individual entity but sublation of mistaken individuality; Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves the jīva eternally.

**Measured model-answer words:** 261

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it answers BOTH obligations (the concept AND the > role of knowledge), and grounds the "knowledge alone" claim in the removal model.

## Verified PYQ 8 — 2021 Q8(b) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Discuss and evaluate the doctrine of Karma as an essential postulate of Hinduism.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** The doctrine of karma is an essential postulate of Hinduism because it supplies a self-regulating moral order that makes rebirth intelligible and desert just; it is defensible against fatalism and moral-luck objections but remains empirically unverifiable.

- **Statement.** Every morally qualified act leaves an unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*) that matures as pleasure or pain; *sancita/prarabdha/agami* classify the debt. Karma requires rebirth, since fruits mature beyond one life.
- **Why a postulate.** It grounds moral responsibility, explains the distribution of fortune without a capricious deity, and secures the justice of *samsara*.
- **Evaluation.** Strength -- it is not fatalism: *purusakara* operates within *daiva*; present effort shapes *agami*. Weakness -- unverifiability, and the moral-luck/victim-blaming risk.
- **Objection -> reply.** Karma blames the sufferer -> reply: it EXPLAINS distribution without LICENSING social judgement; compassion remains obligatory.

**Verdict.** Karma is postulated because it does indispensable work -- justice, responsibility, the intelligibility of rebirth -- but its warrant is inferential and moral, not empirical.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine:** karmically conditioned continuity extends across lives until liberation. Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism assign continuity to an enduring self or soul; Buddhism explains renewed becoming through causal continuity without a permanent self. ✓ **Rebirth in Karma theory (2023 PYQ):** rebirth widens the temporal field in which karmic consequences can mature beyond one life. "Debt" is only an analogy and must not replace each school's own causal account. ✓ **Gītā (2025 PYQ):** the imperishable soul "*casts off worn-out bodies and enters new ones*" — rebirth presupposes the deathless self.

The decisive test is whether the proposed continuity explains numerical identity rather than merely resemblance, and whether it survives the branching and duplication objections.

**Measured model-answer words:** 264

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it both expounds AND evaluates (as asked), > defending karma against fatalism while conceding unverifiability.

## Verified PYQ 9 — 2022 Q5(c) · 10 marks

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**Exact verified question:** "Immortality of Soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth." Critically examine with reference to Buddhism.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** The claim that immortality of the soul is a necessary postulate for rebirth is false as stated: an immortal soul may bear continuity only within an additional transmigration or re-embodiment doctrine. Immortality alone is not sufficient for rebirth, and Buddhist causal continuity shows that a substantial immortal soul is not necessary.

- **The substantialist assumption.** In Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism an eternal *atman/jiva* is exactly what transmigrates, so there immortality is presupposed.
- **The Buddhist refutation.** Buddhism denies a permanent self (*anatman*) yet affirms rebirth (*punarbhava*): what continues is a dependently arisen causal stream, illustrated by a flame passing candle to candle. Rebirth therefore requires CONTINUITY, not an unchanging substance.
- **Objection -> reply.** If no same agent persists, who is reborn and who reaps the fruit? -> the later stream is "neither the same nor wholly other"; moral responsibility rests on causal connectedness.

**Verdict.** Immortality of a substantial soul is neither sufficient by itself nor necessary for rebirth. It becomes a continuity bearer only when a doctrine of transmigration or re-embodiment is also supplied.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ Rebirth is causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates, not transmigration of a numerically identical substance.

**Measured model-answer words:** 191

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it delivers the precise two-part verdict (not sufficient by itself; not necessary) and uses Buddhism as a counter-example, not merely an exception.

## Verified PYQ 10 — 2022 Q7(b) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Is it possible to have an idea of Liberation without the conception of a real agent? In this context, discuss the difference between Advaita and Viśiṣṭādvaita systems of thought.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** An idea of liberation without a "real agent" is coherent, and the Advaita-Visistadvaita dispute is exactly a dispute over whether the liberated subject is an ultimately real individual agent.

- **The paradox.** If Advaita denies ultimate individuality, who is bound and who is liberated?
- **Advaita.** *Moksa* is the sublation of a MISTAKEN individuality, not the annihilation of an entity; conventional agency (*vyavaharika*) operates until liberating knowledge removes the misidentification. The "agent" is real empirically, unreal absolutely -- so liberation needs no ultimately real agent.
- **Visistadvaita.** The *jiva* is a real, eternal mode of God, a genuine agent throughout, bound by karma and freed into communion/service; it never becomes God. So it faces no agent-paradox but pays with irreducible plurality.
- **Objection -> reply.** Advaita's conventional agency looks ad hoc -> reply: the two-truths framework is doing principled work, distinguishing the standpoint of ignorance from that of realisation.

**Verdict.** Liberation without a real (ultimate) agent is coherent on Advaita and denied on Visistadvaita; the difference is not about liberation's possibility but about the ontological status of the one who is free.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ The enduring self bears karmic continuity through embodiments until liberating knowledge or God-centred realisation ends bondage. **Argument.** ✓ Ordinary identity across changing states points to a witness; karmic responsibility requires continuity; *śruti* discloses the self's deeper nature. Advaita locates bondage in ignorance; Viśiṣṭādvaita in dependence and karma overcome through knowledge, devotion and grace. **Presupposition.** ⚠ Personal continuity requires more than causal succession, and scriptural testimony is valid in supersensible matters. **Distinction.** ✓ Advaita mokṣa is not the annihilation of an individual entity but sublation of mistaken individuality; Viśiṣṭādvaita preserves the *jīva* eternally.

**Measured model-answer words:** 270

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it reframes the "real agent" question as the very > axis dividing the two schools, giving each its own answer rather than blending.

## Verified PYQ 11 — 2022 Q8(b) · 15 marks

**Exact verified question:** Discuss the nature of Soul and Bondage according to Jainism.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** In Jainism the soul (*jīva*) is an eternal, conscious substance whose bondage is the literal adhesion of fine karmic MATTER; liberation is the complete stoppage and shedding of that matter.

- **Nature of the soul.** Every living being is an eternal conscious *jīva*, of the size of the body it occupies, whose intrinsic nature is infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy (*ananta-catustaya*), currently obscured.
- **Bondage machinery.** Passions and action ATTRACT karmic particles (*asrava*); they BIND to the soul (*bandha*); restraint STOPS the influx (*samvara*); austerity SHEDS accumulated karma (*nirjara*); the freed *jīva* manifests its full qualities and rises to the summit of the universe (*siddhatva*).
- **Distinction.** Jain liberation PERFECTS individuality -- neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without a self. Jain *kevala* = omniscience, not Samkhya's contentless *kaivalya*.

- **Objection -> reply.** How does non-material consciousness interact with quasi- material karma? -> Jainism treats extension and embodiment as MODES of the *jīva* during bondage; the reply is contested but internally consistent.

**Verdict.** The Jain soul is eternal and intrinsically omniscient, and bondage/ liberation are a quasi-physical process of accretion and removal of karmic matter.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ Every living being is an eternal conscious *jīva* obscured and weighed down by karmic matter; liberation is complete stoppage and shedding of that matter.

**Argument.** ✓ Passions and action attract karmic particles (*āsrava*); bondage (*bandha*) binds them to the soul; restraint stops influx (*saṃvara*); austerity sheds accumulated karma (*nirjarā*); liberated *jīva* manifests infinite knowledge, perception, bliss and energy. **Presupposition.** ⚠ Consciousness belongs intrinsically to an enduring substance and karma is quasi-material. **Distinction.** ✓ Jain liberation perfects individuality; it is neither Advaitic identity nor Buddhist cessation without self.

**Measured model-answer words:** 267

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it delivers BOTH nouns the question names (soul > AND bondage), with the *asrava-bandha-samvara-nirjara* machinery in order.

## Verified PYQ 12 — 2023 Q6(a) · 20 marks

**Exact verified question:** Critically examine Plato's apriori proofs for the immortality of the soul.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Plato's four Phaedo arguments make the soul's immortality suggestive but not demonstrable; assessed separately, each either reaches only pre-existence or rests on an undefended assumption.

- **(1) Opposites (cyclical).** Living and dead arise from each other, so souls persist between lives. *Assessment:* establishes recurrence, not the soul's indestructibility; the analogy from physical opposites is weak.
- **(2) Recollection (anamnesis).** We judge equal sticks by an Equality never perfectly given in sense, so the soul knew it before birth. *Assessment:* proves (at most) PRE-existence, not post-mortem survival.
- **(3) Affinity.** The soul is simple, invisible and akin to the Forms, so it does not decompose. *Assessment:* likeness is not identity; simplicity does not entail indestructibility.
- **(4) Form of Life.** The soul essentially brings Life and cannot admit its opposite, death. *Assessment:* the strongest, but it assumes the soul is essentially life-giving -- the point at issue.
- **Objection -> reply.** Simmias' harmony analogy makes the soul a bodily attunement -> Plato replies the soul RULES the body and pre-exists it.
- **External critique.** Kant's paralogism: the soul is not a knowable substance.

**Verdict.** The arguments are mutually supporting rather than individually conclusive; they render immortality intelligible, not proven.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ In the *Phaedo*, Plato presents the soul as pre-existent and akin to intelligible, non-composite reality, culminating in the claim that soul essentially brings life and cannot admit death. **Argument.** ✓ Cyclical argument: living and dead arise from each other. Recollection: grasp of equality exceeds sensory instances and indicates pre-natal acquaintance. Affinity: soul resembles invisible, stable Forms more than composite body. Final argument: what essentially participates in Life cannot receive its contrary. **Presupposition.** ⚠ Learning is recollection, likeness to the simple supports indestructibility, and essential predicates exclude contraries. **Distinction.** ✓ Pre-existence does not by itself prove post-mortem survival; each argument must bridge both directions. **Canonical example.** ✓ Equal sticks never perfectly instantiate Equality, yet we judge their deficiency by a standard not derived from them alone. **Objection → reply.** ✓ Simmias' harmony analogy makes soul dependent on body; Plato replies that soul governs body and recollection implies prior existence. **Body/brain objection:** systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions pressures separable-soul theories.

**Measured model-answer words:** 352

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- "critically examine" is obeyed by FOUR separate > assessments plus Simmias and Kant, not one summary verdict.

## Verified PYQ 13 — 2023 Q7(b) · 15 marks

**Exact verified question:** Examine the significance of the concept of rebirth in the theory of Karma.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Rebirth is not an optional appendage to the theory of karma but its enabling condition: without further lives, karma's justice -- fruits maturing beyond a single lifetime -- would be impossible.

- **The link.** Karma is act plus unseen potency (*adrsta/apurva*); much of it (*sancita, agami*) matures only in future lives. Rebirth is the FIELD in which those fruits ripen, so karmic desert requires a continued series.
- **Continuity-bearer.** In substantial systems the subtle body carries *samskaras* across births; in Buddhism a causal stream does the same work without a soul -- showing rebirth needs continuity, not necessarily substance.
- **Scriptural note.** *Gita* 9.21: those who exhaust their merit "return to the world of mortals" -- even heaven is a within-*samsara* stage, confirming that desert keeps the wheel turning.
- **Objection -> reply.** Rebirth is unverifiable and morally hazardous -> reply: untestability is shared with resurrection, and explanatory karma does not license blaming the sufferer.

**Verdict.** Rebirth is significant in karma theory as the mechanism of discharge: it is what makes moral desert coherent when one life is too short to settle it.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine:** karmically conditioned continuity extends across lives until liberation. Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism assign continuity to an enduring self or soul; Buddhism explains renewed becoming through causal continuity without a permanent self. ✓ **Rebirth in Karma theory (2023 PYQ):** rebirth widens the temporal field in which karmic consequences can mature beyond one life. "Debt" is only

an analogy and must not replace each school's own causal account. ✓ **Gītā (2025 PYQ):** the imperishable soul "*casts off worn-out bodies and enters new ones*" — rebirth presupposes the deathless self.

**Measured model-answer words:** 264

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it explains the FUNCTION of rebirth within karma > (discharge of desert), not just the fact of it, and adds the continuity point.

## Verified PYQ 14 — 2024 Q5(c) · 10 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Discuss the concept of liberation (*Apavarga*) according to Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** For Nyaya-Vaisesika, liberation (*apavarga*) is the absolute cessation of pain together with the qualities -- including consciousness -- that sustain embodied experience; it is a negative state, not positive bliss.

- **The suffering-chain.** Suffering arises through false knowledge -> defect -> activity -> rebirth -> suffering; true knowledge (*tattva-jnana*) reverses the chain from its root.
- **What liberation is.** The self is an eternal substance to which consciousness is ADVENTITIOUS (arising only through contact with mind and body). In *apavarga* the self persists, but stripped of the nine special qualities including cognition, pleasure and pain -- hence liberation is the end of experience, not its perfection.
- **Distinction.** *Apavarga* differs from positive heavenly pleasure, and from Advaita's blissful *moksa*; it resembles cessation more than fulfilment.
- **Objection -> reply.** A consciousness-less liberation seems undesirable -> reply: Nyaya honestly offers freedom from pain, not a reward; to promise bliss would misdescribe the self.

**Verdict.** *Apavarga* is the cessation of pain and of the very consciousness that makes pain possible -- the sharpest Indian statement of liberation as release rather than beatitude.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ Nyāya liberation is final cessation of pain and pain-generating qualities; Advaita *jīvanmukti* is freedom through knowledge while bodily life continues.

**Measured model-answer words:** 191

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it refuses to sentimentalise *apavarga* as bliss, > grounding "no consciousness" in the adventitious-consciousness doctrine.

## Verified PYQ 15 — 2024 Q6(a) · 20 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Is it necessary to adhere to the notions of immortality of soul and rebirth in order to have a robust conception of liberation? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** A robust conception of liberation requires a continuity-bearer that can be bound across lives and then freed -- but it does NOT require an immortal soul-substance; Buddhism shows liberation is coherent on a causal-continuity model.

- **The apparent necessity.** Liberation is exit from bondage-across-lives, so it seems to presuppose (a) rebirth, and (b) something immortal that is liberated. Vedanta, Nyaya and Jainism satisfy both with an eternal *atman/jiva*.
- **The Buddhist case.** *Anatman* + *pratityasamutpada* deliver rebirth and *nirvana* with no permanent self: the stream that was bound is the stream that ceases to crave. Immortality alone is not sufficient for rebirth, and this Buddhist causal continuity model shows that a substantial immortal soul is not necessary.
- **What IS necessary.** A continuity that can carry desert and then END. Call it substance (substantialists) or stream (Buddhism); either grounds a robust liberation.
- **Objection -> reply.** Without an immortal self, liberation liberates no one -> reply: it liberates the causal series from craving; identity of substance is not required for the coherence of release.

**Verdict.** Immortality and rebirth are the standard scaffolding of liberation but not its logical minimum; the minimum is a morally continuous subject whose bondage can cease -- which Buddhism secures without an eternal soul.

**Analytical expansion. Body/brain objection:** systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions pressures separable-soul theories. It does not by itself deductively prove that no subject can survive, but it shifts the burden to an account of interaction, identity and evidence. **Jīvanmukti (2025 PYQ — Advaita): liberation WHILE living** — the knower of Brahman is free *now*; the body continues by *prārabdha* karma (momentum of a spun wheel) until it drops (videhamukti). ✓ **"Is immortality/rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024):** liberation *presupposes* bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something that is liberated (the soul) — so substantial systems say yes; **Buddhism shows liberation (nirvāṇa) is coherent even without an eternal soul.** ⚠ **Doctrine statement.** ✓ Rebirth is causal continuity of dependently arisen aggregates, not transmigration of a numerically identical substance. **Argument.** ✓ (1) All conditioned factors are impermanent; (2) no aggregate is self; (3) craving and karmic formations condition future consciousness; (4) continuity therefore occurs without an unchanging owner. **Presupposition.** ⚠ Moral responsibility needs causal connectedness, not substance identity.

**Measured model-answer words:** 365

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it gives reasons BOTH ways (as the stem demands), > then fixes the exact modal minimum, using Buddhism as the load-bearing case.

## Verified PYQ 16 — 2025 Q5(d) · 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** Discuss the nature of embodied liberation (jīvanmukti) with reference to Advaita Vedānta.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** *Jivanmukti* in Advaita Vedanta is liberation WHILE EMBODIED: the knower of Brahman is free the moment ignorance is destroyed, though the body continues on residual momentum until death.

- **The doctrine.** *Moksa* is realising *atman* = Brahman by ending *avidya*. Since bondage is ignorance, liberating knowledge frees IMMEDIATELY -- one need not wait for death.
- **Why the body remains.** Already-fructifying *prarabdha* karma sustains the body, like a potter's wheel that spins on after the hand is withdrawn; accumulated (*sancita*) and future (*agami*) karma are burnt by knowledge. *Videhamukti* follows at the body's fall.
- **Character of the *jivanmukta*.** Free from egoic appropriation, acting without binding karma, established in Brahman-consciousness now.
- **Objection -> reply.** If knowledge destroys karma, why any embodiment at all? -> the distinction of *prarabdha* from *sancita/agami* answers exactly this.

**Verdict.** *Jivanmukti* shows Advaitic liberation is a present cognitive- existential transformation, not a post-mortem place or reward -- freedom is realised, not relocated.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ Nyāya liberation is final cessation of pain and pain-generating qualities; Advaita *jīvanmukti* is freedom through knowledge while bodily life continues.

**Measured model-answer words:** 174

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it fixes *jivanmukti* against *videhamukti* and > explains the residual body by *prarabdha*, the exact discriminator examiners want.

## Verified PYQ 17 — 2025 Q7(c) · 15 marks

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**Exact verified question:** Is the concept of immortality of soul a necessary condition for Rebirth? Discuss with reference to the Bhagavad Gītā.

**Demand decoding:** Define the governing concepts, answer every directive limb, compare the relevant schools or arguments, test the strongest objection and close with a graded verdict.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** With reference to the *Bhagavad Gita*, immortality of the soul is presented as the presupposition of rebirth: precisely because the embodied self is imperishable, it "casts off worn-out bodies and enters new ones". Yet, read philosophically, this shows that immortality can support rebirth only inside a wider transmigration doctrine; it is not sufficient by itself and is not necessary.

- **The Gita's teaching.** 2.23 -- weapons, fire, water and wind cannot destroy the self; 2.22 -- the self changes bodies as a person changes worn-out garments. Rebirth here PRESUPPOSES the deathless *atman*.
- **The mechanism.** Driven by karma, the imperishable self takes new embodiments within *samsara*; 9.21 shows even heavenly sojourn ends in return.

- **The wider verdict.** The Gita's model is substantialist, so for IT immortality is necessary. But Buddhism affirms rebirth without an immortal soul, so the necessity is school-relative: the Gītā supplies a deathless continuity bearer within its wider doctrine of transmigration, not a sufficient condition by itself.
- **Objection -> reply.** Does the Gita PROVE immortality? -> No; it ASSERTS it as scriptural teaching and illustrates it (the garment image is illustration, not demonstration).

**Verdict.** In the Gita, immortality of the soul is the necessary ground of rebirth; across traditions, immortality is neither sufficient by itself nor necessary. Soul-based systems require an additional transmigration doctrine, while Buddhism is the counter-model to necessity.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine:** karmically conditioned continuity extends across lives until liberation. Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism assign continuity to an enduring self or soul; Buddhism explains renewed becoming through causal continuity without a permanent self. ✅ **Rebirth in Karma theory (2023 PYQ):** rebirth widens the temporal field in which karmic consequences can mature beyond one life. "Debt" is only an analogy and must not replace each school's own causal account.

**Measured model-answer words:** 290

**Why this structure earns marks:** Why this earns marks -- it stays faithful to the NAMED text (Gita verses) > while still delivering the modal verdict and the Buddhist reservation.

## Coverage-derived original Mains practice

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### Original 1 · 10 marks

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**Question:** Distinguish rebirth from reincarnation, and explain why the distinction is decisive for Buddhism.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

#### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Rebirth is the wider, more neutral term; reincarnation is the narrower term that assumes a substantial soul re-entering flesh -- which is why Buddhism accepts rebirth but not reincarnation.

- **Reincarnation** (*re-enfleshing*) presupposes an enduring soul-substance that passes from body to body; it fits Vedānta, Nyāya and Jainism.
- **Rebirth** (*punarjanma/punarbhava*) names only re-becoming within *samsara*, and can be cashed out with or without a substance.
- **Why decisive for Buddhism.** Buddhism affirms *punarbhava* while denying a permanent self (*anatman*); what continues is a dependently arisen causal stream (flame-to-flame), "neither the same nor wholly other". To call this "reincarnation" would smuggle back the very soul-substance Buddhism denies.

**Verdict.** Use "rebirth" as the genus and reserve "reincarnation" for the substantialist species; only then is Buddhist *punarbhava* correctly described.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✅ **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series.

**Measured model-answer words:** 156

**Why this structure earns marks:** The response defines the controlling distinction, applies it comparatively, states an objection and closes with a qualified verdict.

## Original 2 · 15 marks

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**Question:** Examine whether 'liberation' can be treated as a single concept across the Indian schools.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** 'Liberation' is a family-resemblance term, not a single concept: once the school-specific destinations are separated, the apparent Indian consensus turns out to be a shared vocabulary covering incompatible states.

- **The parity bench.** *Moksa* (Advaita) is realised identity with Brahman; *moksa* (Visistadvaita) is eternal communion with God; *apavarga* (Nyaya) is cessation of pain AND of consciousness; *kaivalya* (Samkhya-Yoga) is the isolation of contentless consciousness; *kevala/siddhatva* (Jain) is perfected omniscient individuality; *nirvana* (Buddhism) is the cessation of craving with no self affirmed.
- **The consciousness test.** These states differ precisely on what survives: Nyaya keeps a self but no consciousness; Advaita keeps non-dual bliss; Samkhya keeps contentless awareness; Jainism keeps omniscience; Buddhism affirms no self. A single concept cannot span "no consciousness" and "infinite bliss".
- **What they share.** Only a formal core: cessation of bondage and exit from *samsara*. That is a family resemblance, not a common essence.
- **Objection -> reply.** Perhaps all are "freedom from suffering"? Reply: even this masks a production/removal split and the identity/isolation divide.

**Verdict.** Treat 'liberation' as a genus with irreducibly different species; fixing the exact term against the parity bench is the first task in any answer.

**Analytical expansion. Jīvanmukti (2025 PYQ — Advaita): liberation WHILE living** — the knower of Brahman is free *now*; the body continues by *prārabdha* karma (momentum of a spun wheel) until it drops (videhamukti). ✅ **"Is immortality/rebirth necessary for a robust conception of liberation?" (2024):** liberation *presupposes* bondage-across-lives (rebirth) and something that is liberated (the soul) — so substantial systems say yes; **Buddhism shows liberation (nirvāṇa) is coherent even without an eternal soul.** ⚠️

**Measured model-answer words:** 262

**Why this structure earns marks:** The response defines the controlling distinction, applies it comparatively, states an objection and closes with a qualified verdict.

## Original 3 · 20 marks

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**Question:** Compare the Western resurrection tradition and the Indian rebirth tradition on the problem of personal identity across death.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Resurrection and rebirth answer different questions and face the identity problem from opposite directions; neither is a version of the other, and on both the question "is the later being the SAME?" remains unresolved.

- **Two structures.** Resurrection (Hebrew-Christian-Islamic) is ONE life: the person is a psychosomatic unity, so survival needs God to re-constitute the whole person, and history ends in judgement. Rebirth (Indian) is a beginningless series in which karma matures across lives until liberation. Oscar Cullmann (1955) argues Greek immortality and Hebrew resurrection are theologically OPPOSED, not complementary.
- **Identity for resurrection.** The gap problem (what exists between death and resurrection?) and the re-assembly ("cannibal") problem (shared atoms) threaten bodily continuity. Standard replies: Aquinas -- the rational soul is the FORM of the body and secures continuity; van Inwagen -- God preserves a core of the body or leaves a simulacrum; Hick -- an exact, unique psychophysical replica, continuous in memory and character, is the same person for all that matters. The duplication objection (God could make two) says the criterion is then not identity.
- **Book support.** Lynne Rudder Baker ("Death and the Afterlife", Oxford Handbook of Philosophy of Religion) sets out four candidate criteria -- same soul, same body, same composite, or continuity of memory -- and surveys Origen's "seed", Augustine's re-collected "statue" and Aquinas's soul-as-form; Bernard Williams's reduplication argument and H. H. Price's image-world sharpen the difficulty.
- **Identity for rebirth.** The memory objection (no recollection of prior lives) is met by distinguishing psychological memory from metaphysical continuity and appealing to latent *samskaras*; in Buddhism identity is dropped altogether in favour of a causal stream "neither the same nor wholly other".
- **Contrast.** Resurrection keeps the body essential; rebirth discards it like a garment (*Gita* 2.22). Resurrection needs a divine agent; rebirth needs only the self-regulating law of karma.

**Verdict.** Resurrection asks how an essentially embodied person can survive; rebirth asks how moral desert can be discharged when one life is too short. Both leave the sameness of the later being contested -- for resurrection because of the gap and duplication, for rebirth because of the missing memory and (in Buddhism) the deliberate abandonment of numerical identity.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series.

**Measured model-answer words:** 384

**Why this structure earns marks:** The response defines the controlling distinction, applies it comparatively, states an objection and closes with a qualified verdict.

## Original 4 · 10 marks

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**Question:** Why must a theory of post-mortem survival distinguish numerical identity from qualitative similarity?

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** Survival means that the later subject is numerically the same person, not merely an exact qualitative copy.

Qualitative similarity can be shared by many entities: two replicas may possess the same memories, character and appearance. Numerical identity, however, is one-to-one and transitive. Hick's replica case therefore gains plausibility only while the replica is unique; the possibility of two equally good replicas reveals that resemblance and psychological continuity do not by themselves select one survivor.

The distinction also disciplines soul theories. Saying that an immaterial soul persists secures identity only if that soul can be individuated and re-identified as this person's soul. Buddhist rebirth deliberately avoids this claim: it preserves causal and moral continuity without asserting an unchanging owner.

**Verdict.** Similarity can support survival-like concern, but a literal identity claim needs a non-branching criterion that explains why the later being is one and the same subject.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.**  **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series.

**Measured model-answer words:** 177

**Why this structure earns marks:** It makes the identity/similarity distinction operational through replica and Buddhist cases.

## Original 5 · 15 marks

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**Question:** Use Strawson's identification conditions to assess the claim that an immaterial soul guarantees personal immortality.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** An immaterial soul would guarantee personal immortality only if it can be identified and re-identified as the same particular; Strawson exposes this neglected condition without independently disproving survival.

In *Individuals*, a person is a basic particular in one public spatio-temporal framework and the bearer of both M-predicates and P-predicates. Other-ascription of psychological states uses public behavioural and situational criteria, while self-ascription is normally non-observational. The concept of a person is therefore not constructed by first identifying a body and a separately identifiable consciousness.

Applied to immortality, the test is exact: after bodily death, what makes a surviving immaterial subject this soul rather than another? Mere persistence of some consciousness, or possession of similar memories, establishes at most qualitative continuity. If the soul lacks public individuation conditions, the theory asserts survival without explaining diachronic identity.

The objection is bounded. Strawson's descriptive metaphysics concerns our actual identification scheme. It does not show that God could not guarantee identity, nor that every substantial-self theory is false.

**Verdict.** Soul-substance may be metaphysically sufficient, but until individuation and re-identification are supplied it is not an adequate criterion of personal immortality.

**Analytical expansion. Body/brain objection:** systematic dependence of memory, personality and agency on bodily conditions pressures separable-soul theories. It does not by itself deductively prove that no subject can survive, but it shifts the burden to an account of interaction, identity and evidence. This package owns personal identity **only insofar as identity controls survival, soul, immortality, resurrection or rebirth**. The bounded comparison with Strawson does not transfer Diachronic identity asks what makes a subject at **t2** numerically identical with a subject at **t1**.

**Measured model-answer words:** 269

**Why this structure earns marks:** It uses Strawson only as a bounded identification-condition test and preserves Paper I ownership.

## Original 6 · 20 marks

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**Question:** Critically compare bodily, psychological, soul-substance and causal-continuity accounts of survival across death.

**Demand decoding:** Establish the exact distinction, compare rival criteria, address the best objection and state a bounded conclusion.

### Independent model answer

**Thesis.** The four accounts preserve different goods: bodily continuity offers public identity, psychological continuity preserves agency and concern, soul-substance promises numerical unity, and causal continuity accommodates rebirth without a self. None is cost-free.

**Bodily continuity.** Ordinary re-identification tracks one organism through space and time. Resurrection theories retain embodiment, but death creates a gap and reassembly raises the cannibal problem. A replica may be qualitatively exact while remaining numerically new.

**Psychological continuity.** Overlapping chains of memory, intention and character explain prudential concern better than sameness of matter. Yet memory can be false or copied, and branching creates two equally continuous successors although identity cannot be one-to-many.

**Soul-substance.** A simple enduring soul appears to secure strict identity despite bodily replacement. Its weakness is epistemic and conceptual: how is an immaterial particular individuated, and what makes the later soul this one? Strawson's public identification condition sharpens this burden.

**Causal continuity.** Buddhism explains rebirth through dependent origination: the later stream is caused by the earlier, neither identical nor wholly different. This protects karma without a permanent self, but critics ask whether responsibility survives when strict identity is denied.

The criteria may also be combined. Hylomorphism links soul and body; divine-guarantee accounts supplement bodily or psychological continuity; narrative identity explains appropriation but cannot defeat duplication alone.

**Verdict.** A complete survival theory must state whether it seeks strict identity or only continuity sufficient for responsibility and concern, then answer discontinuity, circular memory, branching and individuation objections.

**Analytical expansion. Doctrine statement.** ✓ **Resurrection** is the divine re-constitution of the whole embodied person at an eschatological end; **rebirth** is the karmically driven re-embodiment of a continuant within a beginningless series. They are not variants of one idea: they differ in number of lives, mechanism, judge, telos and identity-bearer. **Two Western strands that are often wrongly merged.** ✓ **Immortality of the soul** is Greek/Platonic: the soul is naturally deathless and death releases it from the body. **Resurrection of the dead** is Hebrew-Christian-Islamic: the person is a **psychosomatic unity**, so survival requires God to restore the whole person; death is real and defeat is reversed only by divine act.

**Measured model-answer words:** 350

**Why this structure earns marks:** It compares four criteria under the same objections and reaches a criterion-sensitive verdict.